or sent out of India altogether but for the leader of the winning side. Said Ramesh Prasad Mohapatra in *Military History of Orissa*:

> No war in the history of India is as important either for its intensity or for its results as the Kalinga war of Ashoka. No wars in the annals of the human history has changed the heart of the victor from one of wanton cruelty to that of an exemplary piety as this one. From its fathomless womb the history of the world may find out only a few wars to its credit which may be equal to this war and not a single one that would be greater than this. The political history of mankind is really a history of wars and no war has ended with so successful a mission of the peace for the entire war-torn humanity as the war of Kalinga.

Indeed, once Kalinga fell to Ashoka's forces and was reorganized under the rule of the empire, Emperor Ashoka vowed never again to wage war in order to expand his empire. He had seen destruction, misery, murder, and fear firsthand and was forever changed by it. Known as a bloody and savage ruler beforehand, Emperor Ashoka emerged from the Kalinga War a different ruler. No longer a lapsed Hindu and a bloodthirsty tyrant, he took up the path of the Buddha as many others in his empire had done. The edicts Ashoka had printed upon stone certify that "After the Kalingas had been conquered, Beloved of the Gods began to feel a strong inclination toward the Dhamma, a love for the Dhamma, and for instruction in Dhamma."

Dhamma, also known in Sanskrit as "Dharma," is difficult to translate into English, though scholars have suggested "piety," "morality," and "righteousness" to stand in its place. Essentially a theoretical construct concerning one's spirituality and lifestyle, Dhamma was proposed by the monk Siddhartha Gautama about two centuries before Emperor Ashoka succeeded to his father's throne. Known afterward simply as the Buddha, Siddhartha Gautama taught a life of peace and tranquility to his followers throughout India, giving light to a new spiritual school, that of Buddhism. Siddhartha's original philosophies and teachings evolved over the centuries, eventually to be summarized into five main abstinences: killing living things, lying, intoxication, sexual misconduct, and stealing. This ethical foundation is which lies at the heart of Dhamma, and they are what inspired Emperor Ashoka to engrave the Major Rock Edicts—the continued